

THE FUTURE IS HYBRID

HDFC Bank has not issued any diktat for all employees to return to office and plans to have a hybrid working strategy going forward

By **Ashish Rukhaiyar**

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► **THE TRIGGER MAY** have been Covid-19, but management guru Peter Drucker had seen the signs in the late '80s, says HDFC Bank Chief Human Resources Officer Vinay Razdan. Drucker was of the view that the experiment of moving people from Tier II/Tier III cities into urban centres for employment wasn't working out because people were stressed as they spent more time on roads and their quality of life had suffered. "He said we should shift information to people instead of shifting people to information," says the CHRO, when asked about his experience of managing the bank's employees across the country during the pandemic.

Razdan, who has spent nearly four years at HDFC Bank, believes the pandemic has brought about an irreversible shift globally in the way we work, and while a shift in strategy was needed, it had to be one with a long-term view. The solution seems to be a hybrid mode of work, but more on that later.

First, let's go back to March, 2020. As the pandemic spread, HDFC Bank knew there was a lot of anxiety among employees. So, the first communication that went out to them was that the bank was not considering any reduction in headcount; in fact, the lender hired around 12,000 people during the pandemic.

Further, the bank asked each employee, on a regular basis, three simple questions: 'Are you okay?', 'Is your family okay?' and 'Do you need any help?'. "Some of these things you can't really quantify in money terms. These make a big difference to the lives of employees and those are the moments of truth in which you form and build trust or enhance the trust factor with employees," says Razdan, who has been in the field for three decades, and has worked with companies like ITC, HCL Technologies and Idea Cellular.

HDFC Bank also put in place a 'compassion package' for the families of employees who succumbed to Co-

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LONG-TERM VIEW Vinay Razdan, CHRO, HDFC Bank

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HDFC BANK

Top 3 attributes

- Clarity of company goals
- Culture of innovation
- Growth and learning opportunities